taken by Russia for the increase of her trade in Central Asia' – a very similar remit to that Nesselrode had given Vitkevitch.[37]

Auckland's protocol-obsessed Political Secretary, William Macnaghten, meanwhile, had ordered that given the dubious nature of Kabul's Barakzai rulers, who in the official view of Calcutta had usurped the throne of Afghanistan's true monarch, Shah Shuja, a 'strict economy' was to be observed, and Burnes's mission was to travel with far less pomp and many fewer presents than that of Elphinstone: Burnes in fact had only a single pistol and one telescope to give to Dost Mohammad. In the light of lingering Afghan memories of the lavishness of the gifts given by the last Embassy to Shah Shuja, these instructions did not bode well for the success of Burnes's mission. Nor did the news of a pitched battle between the Sikhs and the Afghans which had erupted even as Burnes was heading towards the new Khyber frontier separating the two.

The Battle of Jamrud on 30 April 1837 was the climax of three years' growing hostility between the Afghans and the Sikhs over Ranjit Singh's occupation of Peshawar. As soon as he had dealt with Shah Shuja's invasion of 1834, Dost Mohammad had turned his attention to trying to liberate the Afghan winter capital from Sikh control. Whether out of piety or strategy, or a mixture of the two, in February 1835 he had himself awarded the Islamic title of Amir al-Muminin, the Commander of the Faithful, by the 'ulema [clergy] of Kabul: the most senior Sunni cleric in Kabul, the Mir Waiz, had led him to the Id Gah on the edge of the town and placed barley shoots in his turban, an echo of the ceremony by which a sufi saint had consecrated Shah Shuja's grandfather, Ahmad Shah Abdali, in June 1747.[1] As the *Siraj ul-Tawarikh* noted,

> Calling the men of the surrounding region into Kabul, Dost Mohammad declared a jihad [holy war] and announced that the Punjab, Peshawar, and the other regions would be regained.
>
> The religious scholars who called for jihad as an obligation to God, and who considered killing and being killed on the path of religion the catalyst of a better age, and the way to obtain life itself, gathered in joy and declared that: 'The command to jihad is dependent on the existence of an amir and the establishment of an Amirate. Whoever should turn away from his command or prohibition, it would be like disobedience to the order of God and the Prophet. For others, it is absolutely essential that they render him obedience and punish those who disobey.' Thanks to this declaration . . . Dost Mohammad began laying the foundations of his Amirate. In a short time, he had put everything in order, ascended the throne, and had the coinage and the *khutbah* [the Friday sermon] issued in his name. The following verse was inscribed on the coinage: